CJ Nowacek

Technical Artist & Pipeline Developer

Cleveland Heights, Ohio
(216) 469 0959
cj@cjnowacek.com
cjnowacek.com
cjnowacek

Professional Summary

Technical artist and pipeline developer who shipped **SMITE 2** at Hi-Rez Studios: character rigging plus the Python/MaxScript tooling behind the asset pipeline, with contract technical-art work in Unreal Engine 5. Now building production infrastructure for an architectural visualization studio (PyQt desktop tooling, render-farm automation, cross-DCC workflows) and co-teaching 3D rigging as adjunct faculty at the Cleveland Institute of Art, so tools stay grounded in how artists actually think and work.

Core Skills

Programming	Python (Maya API, PyMEL, PyQt/PySide, pymxs, pytest), MaxScript, MEL, Bash, Git, Perforce
DCC/Engines	3ds Max, Maya, Unreal Engine 5, Unity, Substance Painter
Focus	Character rigging, pipeline development, asset and scene optimization, render-farm automation

Professional Experience

2026–Present **CGI Pipeline Developer**, *MediaLab 3D Solutions*, Remote

- Designed and built a Python scene-automation framework for scene cleanup, optimization, diagnostics, and render-farm submission, accessible via CLI, PyQt desktop app, and native 3ds Max integration
- Developed a MaxScript batch-rendering suite that classifies objects across XRef-linked scenes and automatically renders material/finish combinations, replacing a manual per-option workflow with one-click submission
- Built artist-facing tools for the studio's central 3ds Max toolset (lighting, visualization, camera, CAD-import QA, and export utilities), modernized its legacy MaxScript, and own the build-and-release workflow that ships it to production
- Built an AI-assisted development workflow with regression tests and independent review before release
- Author documentation and train production staff on each tool

2026–Present **Adjunct Faculty, Animation**, *Cleveland Institute of Art*, Cleveland, OH

- Co-teach ANIM 312, 3D Rigging & Problem Solving, in Maya: IK/FK limbs, spline spines, ribbons, correctives, dynamics, mocap retargeting
- Advise BFA seniors on senior projects, portfolios, and demo reels, and on preparing for technical-art and animation roles

2026 **MaxScript Specialist (Contract)**, *MediaLab 3D Solutions*, Remote

- Built MaxScript and Python automation for asset processing and repetitive scene operations in 3ds Max; converted to full-time pipeline developer role

2025 **Technical Artist (Contract)**, *Anuttacon via GoDemic*, Remote

- Developed automated asset-processing tools in Python and MEL, iterating on feedback to improve usability and reliability
- Wrote user documentation and incorporated stakeholder feedback to meet production needs

2024–2025 **Technical Animator (Contract)**, *Hi-Rez Studios*, Remote

- Built Python and MaxScript automation for asset integration and deployment in Unreal Engine 5
- Collaborated with Animation, Design, and QA to find bottlenecks and automate milestone-delivery steps

2023–Present **Rigging Artist (Freelance)**, *Independent*, Remote

- Character rigging for original characters and independent projects in Maya, including custom rigs for *Grimmlins Tale*

2023–2024 **Associate Technical Animator**, *Hi-Rez Studios*, Alpharetta, GA

- Shipped **SMITE 2** as part of the technical animation team: character rigging alongside the Python/MaxScript tooling that supported the asset pipeline
- Built and refined character rigs for SMITE 2, partnering with animation to deliver production-ready assets
- Optimized character assets for runtime performance in a live multiplayer title, keeping rigs and skinned meshes in budget
- Developed automated batch-processing tools in Python and MaxScript, cutting manual asset-processing time by **25%**
- Built automated asset-migration pipelines across engine versions, reducing integration errors

2022–2023 **Technical Animator Intern**, *Hi-Rez Studios*, Remote

- Developed Python scripts to automate repetitive production tasks and built optimization tools for common bottlenecks

Education

2023 **BFA, Animation and Game Design**, *Cleveland Institute of Art*, Cleveland, OH
Senior Project: Cinematic story driven game

Updated October 18, 2026